

Collaborative Learning Discussion: Initial Post

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The findings of Hancock et al. (2024) demonstrate that while data and digital technologies have strengthened the capacity to identify human rights abuses, they can also undermine fairness and accountability when implemented without sufficient contextual understanding. Data-driven investigations frequently rely on remote sensing, satellite imagery, artificial intelligence, and Open-Source Intelligence (OSINT). However, these technologies often operate within data-poor environments where incomplete, inaccurate, or biased datasets can lead to misinterpretation, exclusion of vulnerable groups, and unfair investigative outcomes (Hancock et al., 2024a). Furthermore, excessive reliance on technological surveillance may compromise privacy, reinforce existing power imbalances, and distance investigators from the lived experiences of affected communities (Hancock et al., 2024b). This can reduce trust in investigative processes, discourage reporting, and ultimately weaken the legitimacy of findings (United Nations Human Rights Office, 2021).

A significant risk arises when technological solutions are designed without meaningful participation from the communities they seek to protect. Hancock et al. (2024a) found that many existing tools prioritise sophisticated technological innovation rather than addressing practical community needs, resulting in solutions that are poorly aligned with local realities and therefore underutilised. This techno-solutionist approach may reduce trust, overlook contextual knowledge, and weaken accountability. To mitigate these risks, developers should adopt participatory and human-centred design approaches that involve affected communities throughout the design process. Co-design, continuous stakeholder engagement, transparency regarding data use, and

investment in accessible low-tech solutions can improve fairness, strengthen community agency, and ensure technologies complement rather than replace human judgement (Hancock et al., 2024a; Hancock et al., 2024b). International frameworks, such as UNESCO's Recommendation on the Ethics of Artificial Intelligence, emphasise that inclusive governance and stakeholder participation are essential to ensuring that technology promotes rather than undermines human rights (UNESCO, 2021).

References

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